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NOT SO LONG AGO, the ideal workplace was one that offered a competitive salary. Not anymore. The increasing proportion of younger millennial and Gen Z employees now look beyond financial comforts and demand a more holistic work life that gives them time to enjoy other pursuits and the chance to learn on the job.

Over the past four years, the workplace has seen huge shifts necessitated by the pandemic, which has made remote working the norm. These changes have also forced recruiters at most Indian firms to tweak policies as they look to match up to the ambitions of younger employees and retain talent.

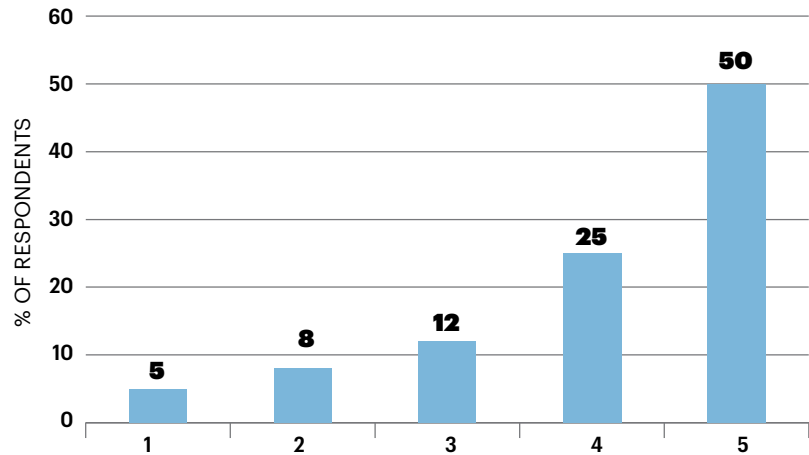
Once seen as western concepts, hybrid work, a more inclusive and equitable work culture, and, more importantly, a focus on upskilling employees to keep pace with technological advancements (like artificial intelligence and machine learning) and leadership courses are now becoming an integral part of the HR talent hunt modules.

There is also more investment in office infrastructure and parking facilities, four-day work weeks for employees who meet their targets ahead of schedule, and reworking rewards and recognitions for long-serving employees.

DIVERSITY PRIORITY

● Organisations placed diversity and inclusion initiatives very high on their list of priorities in the second half of FY24

● 50% organisations give such initiatives a rating of 5 out of 5, underlining their importance



FIGURES REPRESENT % OF RESPONDENTS

SOURCE TEAMLEASE EMPLOYMENT OUTLOOK REPORT- H2FY24

In fact, these are some of the innovative strategies being taken up by the top firms in this year's *BT-Taggd* survey of The Best Companies To Work For in India.

WRITING ON THE WALL

The survey finds that some of these perks are also catching on with older workers, who now see flexibility as a top priority. About 42% of respondents aged 50 and above value assignment flexibility the most, followed by quality of work (39%). Hybrid is the preferred model overall, but the work-from-home (WFH) preference is stronger for lower-paid workers. The survey found that 42% of those earning less than ₹4 lakh annually prefer WFH, compared to 33% of those earning above ₹12 lakh.

Work-life balance is very important for employees. For the majority of respondents, the ability to man-

age personal engagements with work ranks the highest, followed by getting a chance to focus on individual and family well-being. This signals a rising demand for comprehensive well-being initiatives extending beyond mere flexibility in work hours.

Upskilling initiatives like training them in Generative AI (Gen AI) are considered a welcome step by employees, but less than 50% of respondents say their employers are training them in Gen AI. One out of 10 employees says they have not received any support from their employer. This suggests a potential hurdle for organisations that might have begun implementing Gen AI but haven't equipped their workforce to use it effectively.

Indeed, several talent acquisition reports highlight three key focus areas for today's recruiters: the culture of a 10 to 6 job is being